

# The Journey to the Land of Youth

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, an old, bright salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is full of ideas, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



*Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.*

### Before you begin

A small friend of the village has not come home. Yesterday, the story goes, they glimpsed a white deer at the edge of the trees and followed it, down to the Misty Loch and out across the still grey water, into the Land of Youth. That is the gentle Otherworld beyond the mist, once called Tir na nOg, where the apple trees are always in blossom and no one ever grows old. It is the loveliest place in any tale. That is exactly the danger of it: the longer a soul lingers there, the more they forget the faces and the way back home.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver called the two of you to the warm hearth of the Roundhouse. "You have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth far more across the mist than any sword. Will you go after our friend and bring them home, gently, before the memory of us fades altogether?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a sprig of oak for luck, a honey oatcake wrapped in a cloth, and a ball of bright red wool. "Remember," she said, "across the mist we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas. And we keep our promises."



*What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Kindness?*

### Stop 1 The Salmon's Riddle

The path led you down to the shore of the Misty Loch, where the water lay flat and grey and the far bank was lost in soft white mist. There seemed no way across at all, and no boat in sight.

Then the surface broke, and up rose a great old salmon, his scales bright as worn silver: the Salmon of Wisdom, who is said to know the answer to every riddle ever asked. "I know the way across the loch," he said, in a voice like slow water, "and I am glad to share it. But first you must answer a riddle of mine. I am fair, and I am kind, so think well and do not fear."



*Will you listen closely and puzzle it out together? A brave, thoughtful guess is welcome too, for the salmon is no trickster. What do you try?*

When your answer came, the salmon dipped his great head and swished his tail, sending slow rings across the loch. "Well thought," he said, almost smiling, and he told you where on the shore to wait for the one who could carry you across.

### Stop 2 The Selkie's Crossing

Where the salmon had pointed, among the whispering reeds, a small wooden boat lay ready, and beside it waited Sorcha the Selkie, a gentle seal-person wrapped in a soft grey sealskin

cloak. She had dark, kind eyes, but she would not quite lift them to yours. She seemed terribly shy, and lonelier than the whole grey loch, as though no one had spoken a warm word to her in years.

★ *This was never a thing to win by force. What kindness could you offer her? You might give her a gentle word, or tell her she is not alone, or share the honey oatcake that Maeve gave you. What do you do?*

When you offered your kindness, something in Sorcha softened, and she smiled, slow and surprised, as if she had half forgotten how. "I will carry you across," she said quietly. "Climb in, and stay close." She took up the oars and rowed you out into the mist, and on the far shore, shimmering through the white, the Land of Youth came slowly into view.

### Stop 3 The Land of Youth

You stepped from the boat into the Otherworld, and it took your breath away. Apple trees stood everywhere in soft pink blossom, the light fell warm and golden, and the air itself seemed to hum with a sleepy, happy peace. And there, in the middle of a meadow of flowers, was your small friend, laughing, as though no trouble had ever existed anywhere.

But when you called their name, they turned slowly, and their eyes were misty. "Oh," they said, "do I know you? It doesn't matter. Stay. Stay here with me. Nothing hurts here, and no one ever has to leave." It was the gentlest danger you had ever faced, and the hardest, because part of you wanted to stay too.

Then you remembered home: the warm hearth of the Roundhouse, the people who loved you, the way the Misty Loch caught the first light of dawn. You held that memory close, the way you hold the end of a thread.

★ *This is not a fight, and there is nothing here to defeat. How will you help your friend remember home? You might tell them, gently, about the people waiting and the hearth still warm. You might tie the red wool fast so that none of you can lose the way back. What do you do, together?*

Slowly, kindly, you gave your friend their home again: a name, a face, a warm hearth, a path through the mist. The fog lifted from their eyes, and they took your hand. "Home," they whispered. "I remember. Let's go home, all of us, together." You tied the red wool fast at the water's edge, and then you chose, every one of you, to turn back toward the boat.

### Home Across the Mist

Sorcha was waiting, and she rowed you all back across the loch, the red wool slipping through your fingers to guide you, every pull of the oars carrying you nearer home. The mist thinned, then parted, and there was the green home shore, bright in the morning sun, your small friend safe and smiling between you.

You had come home together, and you had won a selkie friend besides, for Sorcha promised to visit the shallows whenever you called. High on the brightening green hills, Danu the Kind looked down and smiled, for the tale had ended the only way the best tales do: not by force, but with courage, with kindness, and above all with bright ideas, and with a promise kept. Well done, heroes of the Emerald Isles.

# The Journey to the Land of Youth: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the whole game works; read it first if this is new. This page holds only what is special about this story. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, set in the misty Otherworld with its quiet pull to stay forever, but good ideas and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

## Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the home loch shore.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a twig or leaf for the sprig of oak, a small cake or token for the honey oatcake, and a ball of string or red wool. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

## The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

| Roll | Twist of Fate                                                      |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.                 |
| 2    | You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.        |
| 3    | A soft breeze drifts off the loch, and the next challenge is Easy. |
| 4    | The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.            |
| 5    | A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.         |
| 6    | A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.        |

## How it ends

There is no foe in this tale and nothing to defeat. The only danger is the gentle pull of the Land of Youth, the temptation to stay forever in that lovely, forgetful place. The story is won not by beating anyone but by remembering home: the heroes gently help their half-forgetful friend recall the people and hearth waiting for them, tie the red wool so all can find the way back, and choose, kindly and together, to return across the mist. Let that choosing land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

# The Journey to the Land of Youth: Puzzles and Solutions

*For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.*

## Stop 1: The Salmon's Riddle (Normal)

**The challenge.** The Salmon of Wisdom will not show the way across the Misty Loch until the players answer his riddle. He is fair and kind, and he wants them to do well.

**The riddle.** Read it aloud: *"I am not a bird, and yet I fly. I have no wings, yet I cross the sky. I cannot be caught and I cannot be kept, and I am gone the moment you turn to look. What am I?"* The answer is **the mist** (or a cloud, which the salmon accepts just as gladly, since both drift over the loch).

**Intended solution.** This is a thinking challenge of Imagination and a little patience. Let the children talk it through together. The salmon accepts the right answer, and because he is kind, he also accepts a brave, thoughtful guess.

**Fallback.** If they are stuck, the salmon offers a clue ("You have walked through me all morning, and you cannot hold me in your hand"), or Pook the Puca whispers the answer from the reeds. A guess made bravely still earns the way across.

**Make it simpler.** For a little one, point around and ask, "What floats over the loch that we can walk through but never hold?" Pointing at the mist is the whole answer.

## Stop 2: The Selkie's Crossing (Normal)

**The challenge.** Sorcha the Selkie has the only boat, but she is shy and a little lonely and will not meet the heroes' eyes. They must win her trust to be ferried across the mist. This is never won by force or by demanding.

**Intended solution.** This is a Kindness and Courage moment. Any genuine warmth works: a gentle word, telling her she is not alone, asking her name, or sharing the **honey oatcake**. It takes a little courage to speak first to a shy stranger. When the children are kind, Sorcha smiles, takes up the oars, and rows them across.

**Fallback.** If the children freeze or are unsure what to say, have Sorcha sniffle softly and murmur, "Nobody ever stops to talk to me." A single kind word melts her shyness. Sharing even a crumb of the oatcake counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

**Make it simpler.** For a little one, just ask them to wave and say "hello, would you like to be friends?" That one friendly hello is enough to win Sorcha over.

## Stop 3: The Land of Youth (Hard, then no roll)

**The challenge.** In the ever-blossoming Otherworld the heroes find their lost friend, but the friend has half-forgotten home and gently urges everyone to stay forever. The pull to stay is the only danger, and the players may feel it too. There is nobody to defeat.

**Intended solution.** This is a Kindness and Imagination moment. The good, kind move is to give the friend their home back: talk warmly about the Roundhouse, the people who love them, the home loch at dawn, until the memory returns. Tying the **ball of red wool** at the water's edge is the bright idea that lets them all retrace the way back through the mist. When the friend remembers, everyone chooses, together, to return. After that choice there is no roll: the way home is simply taken.

**Fallback.** If the children are unsure, have the friend pause and ask, very quietly, "Wait... was there someone who used to sing to me at night?" Any warm memory the children offer brings the friend the rest of the way back. The red wool guarantees nobody loses the path, however misty it grows.

**Make it simpler.** For a little one, ask them to name one person at home they love and miss; saying that one name is enough to help the friend remember and choose home.

## The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the friend remembers and chooses home, Sorcha ferries them all back across the loch by the trail of red wool, the mist parts on a bright green shore, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down from the hills. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas, and by keeping their promise to bring their friend home.

# Wander and Tales

## Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.